Translator brief: the Gudea Cylinders (temple-building corpus), 2026-10-20

▼ Contents

0. Read first (binding, in this order) 1
1. Rules learned the hard way (put them first) 1
2. The annotated file (guidelines §7.2) 3
3. Tools 4
4. Before you finish (each run) 4

A common brief for the sequential translators of `גליליות-גודאה-1/` (ETCSL 2.1.7 / ORACC Q000377). Reusable for any later Sumerian royal or building text. Adapted from `../קינות-על-ערים/translator-brief--laments.md`. The coordinator's per-run prompt says which lines are yours.

0. Read first (binding, in this order)

1. `../translation-guidelines.md` — whole. Especially §1 (**two purposes**: the Bible comparison *and* "the soul of the ancients"), §5 (workflow and lessons), §6 (principles; echo control §6.4; false friends §6.7), §6.8 (brackets), §7.2 (the annotated format).
2. `corpus.md`, then `renderings.md` (**all of it is binding**; §3 the formulas and key terms, §4–§5 the reserved and gated words, §6 the vocalization traps).
3. The inherited renderings (`renderings.md` §0): `../קינות-על-ערים/renderings.md` and `../סיפורי-הבריאה-המסופוטמיים/renderings.md` §5–§8 – the default for every word not in our file. Skim `../קינות-על-ערים/annotated-1.rtl.md` (the most recent model for format and depth of apparatus).
4. `גליליות-גודאה-1/project.md` (the runs so far, open decisions, proposals) and `גליליות--גודאה/renderings.md`, and **read the earlier annotated files of this project in full** before you start (at least the `>` lines; `python3 -I temple_tools.py grep GU '<regex>'`).

1. Rules learned the hard way (put them first)

- **Draft unvocalized, in plene spelling (כתיב מלא), from the very first line.** Vocalize only names at their first occurrence in your file, ambiguous words, and the ★ names and traps of renderings §1 and §6 (An `אַן`, Utu `אוּתוּ`, Inana `אִינַנְּה`, Bau `בָּאוּ`, Magan `מָגָן`, Keš `כֶּשׁ`, Sumer `שׁוּמֶר`, Šar-ur `שַׁר־אוּר`, *me* `אֵלִי` , `אָמָה` , `אוֹת` , `הַ־מָה`, every *ĝar* form `שָׂם` …). Never strip niqqud with a naive regex (it deletes the maqaf): keep [redacted]. In five earlier corpora translators who drafted vocalized had to rewrite everything.

- **Translate the Sumerian, not the English.** Form your reading from the transliteration, ETCSL's TEI lemmas (`../tools/sumerian_workbench.py lemmas ../sources/ETCSL/2.1.7--Gudea-Cylinders/c.2.1.7.xml FROM-TO` – ETCSL composite numbers, see `גלילות--1 גודאה/concordance.md`), **the ORACC lemma + morph line in your data file** (ETCSRI's analysis, the best available for this text) and ePSD2 (`sumerian_workbench.py gloss`). Read the two rank-3 translations (ETCSL's English, complete; ETCSRI's English after Edzard 1997, partial) **only afterwards**, and record every disagreement. The English translations of this text are full of the Bible's building language ("holy", "temple", "plan", "glory", "as one man", "Amanus"): check each word against the Sumerian (renderings §4).
- **The verbal chain.** In the **פירוק** bullet parse every finite verb: modal prefix (*ḫe₂-*, *ga-*, *u₃-*, *nu-*, *na-*, *ba-ra-*), conjugation prefix (*mu-*, *i₃-*, *ba-*, *bi₂-*, *im-ma-*, *am₃-*), dimensional infixes (*-na-*, *-da-*, *-ta-*, *-ši-*, *-ni-*), agent (*-n-* / *-b-*), base (ḫamṭu / marû, reduplication) and suffixes; say where the analysis comes from (ORACC morph, or **"ניתוח שלנו"**).
- **Grammar mapping:** renderings §2 (narrative marû = participle; ḫamṭu = past; *ḫe₂-* + ḫamṭu in narrative = `אָכְנָ`; *ga-* = cohortative; *u₃-* = "when"; non-finite *-a* = relative; *nu-* = `לֹא`, never `טֶרֶם`).
- **One line = one Hebrew line**, with the RIME label (`### A.i.1`). Keep the break, the order of images, the parallelism, and **every repetition: identical Sumerian → identical Hebrew.** This text repeats on a large scale: the dream as told (A iv 14 – v 10) and as interpreted (A v 11 – vi 13); Nanše's instructions (A vi 14 – vii 8) and their execution (A vii 9 – 30); the god's promises (A ix – xii) and their fulfilment (A xv – xxiv); the ruler's prayers in A and their echo in B; the entries of the divine household in B (one formula per god); the colophons. Before drafting a repeated line, look for the earlier copy (`python3 -I temple_tools.py grep GU '<string>'`, and `verify`'s "same transliteration, different Hebrew" list) and copy its Hebrew; vary only where the Sumerian varies.
- **Brackets** (guidelines §6.8): a word whose root is broken in the composite is in `[]`; `[...]` for a lost stretch; `...` for a word ETCSL leaves untranslated or an `X`; `()` added for sense; `?` uncertain reading; **נטוי** uncertain translation; `⟨⟩` scribal omission. ETCSL's lost lines (the gaps in its composite numbers, `concordance.md`) have no entry; note them in the section heading's paragraph or the next entry's **הערות**.
- **Reserved and gated strings** (renderings §4–§5) are checked by script; the run fails if one slips in. Before you choose a word the Bible comparison needs, check that the Sumerian word is the one the renderings assign to it. **Tag every such word in the apparatus.** Never use a reserved Tabernacle word (חֲמַת לֵב, קֹדֶשׁ, נְדָבָה, מְלָאכָה, תַּבְנִית, כָּבוֹד, מִשְׁכָּן ...) in a `>` line: name it in the **הקבלה** bullet.

- **Bible quotations** in the apparatus: vocalized, in backticks, followed by the reference in the repository's format (`(שמות מ:לד)`), copied from `../../../תנך-מנוקד/` (`python3 -I ../tools/check_bible_quotes.py --show "שמות "מ לד"` prints a verse) and verified with `python3 -I ../tools/check_bible_quotes.py <file>`. Hebrew Bible numbering (e.g. Deut 5:13 for "that your slave may rest", 1 Kgs 5:20 for the cedars). Fix every mismatch. Keep the `-` of Psalms and Proverbs. **Never quote from memory: print the verse first.**

2. The annotated file (guidelines §7.2)

Header (Hebrew): title `# תרגום מוער – גליליות גודאה (חלק N: <range>)`; then paragraphs **נוסח הבסיס**, **פירוק** (where lemmas and morph come from), **מספור** (RIME labels = ETCSL = ORACC; the ETCSL composite numbers in `concordance.md`; lost lines in your range), **תגי סימנים**, **תרגומים להשוואה**, **הקבלה**, one or more paragraphs that explain your part of the text on its own terms (first file: who Gudea was, Lagaš II, the E-ninnu, the cylinders as objects and as a hymn in three parts; later files: your part of the story), **שמות**, **מלים שמורות**. Then `---`, then sections `## <from>–<to>: <Hebrew heading>` (the clean translation takes its headings from these; divide by content, about 10–40 lines per section), then one entry per line:

```
### A.v.12
`sipad-ĝu₁₀ ma-mu-zu ĝe₂₆ ga-mu-ra-bur₂-bur₂`
> רועי, את חלומך אני — אפשור לך.
- **פירוק:** … (every word; the verbal chain; the source of the morph)
- **תרגומים:** ETCSL: "…"; ETCSRI: "…" — agreement / disagreement and why.
- **הקבלה:** [cognate] `(דניאל ב:ד) וּפִשְׁרָא נְהֵוֵא` — … (only real contacts; mark ou
- **הערות:** the line on its own terms.
- **הערת שוליים:** (optional) one sentence the clean translation should carry as
```

- The transliteration line is copied **exactly** from your data file's `ETCSL:` line (`python3 -I temple_tools.py lines GU A.i.1 A.i.29` prints it too); the script ignores ETCSL's `...` notes and variant parentheses, nothing else may differ.

- **הערות matters as much as הקבלה** (guidelines §1). Explain the text on its own terms wherever an ancient hearer would have heard more than the words say: the dream and its interpretation by Nanše (incubation, the dream-inquirer, the symbols and how they are decoded); extispicy and the brick-mould ritual; the temple as a living being (it "lifts its head", "roars", is a mountain, an Anzud bird, a bull); the god as king and owner of the house, the ruler as his steward; the gods' household staff installed in the house (Cyl. B) – a temple is run like an estate; the ruler's piety (prayers, offerings, sleeplessness, purity); the economy and the long-distance trade (Elam, Susa, Magan, Meluḫḫa, cedar from the mountains, stone, copper, gold, bitumen) and the labour levy by clans; Lagaš's theology (Ninĝirsu, Bau, Nanše, Ĝatumdug, Ninĝišzida, Nisaba, Enki); the festival of equality and justice; what "fate" (*nam*) means. Not every line needs a note; the ones that open the ancient mind do. Explain even where there is no biblical parallel.
- Not every line has a parallel; never force one. **[absent]** and **[divergence]** are findings too.

3. Tools

- `python3 -I temple_tools.py data GU FROM TO <scratchpad>/data.md` — your line data (ETCSL transliteration, ORACC lemma + morph, the two rank-3 translations at their first line). The coordinator gives you a ready file.
- `python3 -I temple_tools.py verify GU` (coverage, transliteration = ETCSL, one `>` per entry, reserved/gated strings, name traps, formulas, identical lines); `grep GU|all '<regex>'` (how a Hebrew string was used so far; `all` adds the lament corpus and the creation corpus's Sumerian texts); `lines GU FROM TO`.
- `python3 -I ../tools/sumerian_workbench.py lemmas|line <c.xml> FROM-TO` (ETCSL composite numbers), `morph '<form>'`, `conc '<regex>'` (ETCSL-wide concordance: formulas recur in hymns and royal texts – look them up before fixing a line), `gloss '<regex>'`.
- The clean translation is **generated** by the coordinator (`temple_tools.py build GU`). Never write `translation.rtl.md` by hand.

4. Before you finish (each run)

1. Three review passes over your lines (guidelines §5.6: fidelity; consistency with `renderings.md` and the earlier Hebrew; Hebrew read aloud), each a separate read-through; record them in `project.md` ("Progress").
2. `python3 -I temple_tools.py verify GU` clean for your lines (notes about not-yet-drafted files are fine); `python3 -I ../tools/check_bible_quotes.py <your annotated file>` clean.

3. In `project.md`, under your run's heading: the **parallels index** `### Parallels index (<KEY>)` (KEY = your file's key: A1, A2, A3, A4, B1, B2, B3) as a table with exactly the columns `| Line | Sumerian | Hebrew rendering | Bible | Tag | Comment |` (the header row starts with `| Line`; Line = the RIME label, e.g. `A.v.12`; Bible = the vocalized verse(s) in backticks followed by the reference); your **key findings** (Bible; and the ancient mind) in a few sentences; your **open decisions** (numbered); and **Proposals for the corpus renderings** (new terms or formulas a later run will need, with the Hebrew strings exactly as you used them).
4. Add your text-specific terms to `גליליות-גודאה-1/renderings.md` (table: Sumerian | Hebrew | Tag | Notes | Lines).
5. Do **not** edit the corpus files (`corpus.md`, `renderings.md`, `parallels-index.md`, the tools), the guidelines, or any other project: the coordinator merges. Do not commit. Leave no background job running.
6. Final message to the coordinator (short): lines done, verify / quote-check status, the strongest findings (Bible, and the ancient mind), open decisions, and any deviation from the corpus renderings (with the reason).